

Congo



Astride the equator in west-central Africa, this former French colony emerged from 20 years of Marxist-Leninist rule in 1990. Democracy was soon overshadowed by years of violence.



GEOGRAPHY

Mostly forest- or savanna-covered plateaus, drained by the Ubangi and Congo river systems. Narrow coastal plain is lined with sand dunes and lagoons.



CLIMATE

Hot, tropical. Temperatures rarely fall below 86°F (30°C). Two wet and two dry seasons. Rainfall is heaviest south of the equator.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

One of the most tribally conscious and heavily urbanized countries in Africa, with most people living in the Brazzaville–Pointe-Noire region. Main tensions are between the Bakongo in the north and the Mboshi in the south. Relative peace was secured in 1999, and “ninja” rebels in the Pool region, around Brazzaville, signed a peace deal in 2003.



THE ECONOMY

Oil provides over 95% of export revenue. Timber is extracted. Foreign debt high. Substantial industrial base around Brazzaville and Pointe-Noire.



INSIGHT: In 1970, Congo became the first African country to declare itself a communist state



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of the Congo

DATE OF FORMATION: 1960

CAPITAL: Brazzaville

POPULATION: 3.68 million

TOTAL AREA: 132,046 sq. miles
(342,000 sq. km)

DENSITY: 28 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Kongo, Teke, Lingala, French*

RELIGIONS: Traditional 50%, Catholic 25%, Protestant 23%, Muslim 2%

ETHNIC MIX: Bakongo 51%, Teke 17%, other 16%, Mboshi 11%, Mbédé 5%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: CFA franc = 100 centimes